



Assignment Writing Guide

How you approach your assignments is a matter of personal choice. It may depend on your experience as a learner, your preferred learning style, the time you have available, and your objectives as a learner on a programme. You may discuss this with your tutor and colleagues during your programme induction and during the on campus time.

Whilst there is no prescribed template for your assignment, here are some hints and tips that will help you to ensure that your assignment meets the criteria and is not returned for further work.

Submission Process

Complete the learning on the VLE, attend the tutor-led workshop, and attempt any additional questions on the VLE under Test and Apply. Also make sure you talk to your tutor and colleagues on the programme; how are they approaching the assignment? What can you learn from them? What learning points did they take from the workshop?

Write your assignment, based on the Assessment Criteria (ACs) for the unit. You should always discuss the assignment with your tutor before you leave the workshop. The ACs are grouped by Learning Outcomes (and there are between two and four Learning Outcomes and up to 15 Assessment Criteria per assignment).

Submit your assignment electronically to your tutor. Your tutor will explain how you should do this, and set you a deadline as a group.

Your tutor will mark your assignment, based on the Assessment Criteria, and return your personal written feedback, usually by email. There is no minimum pass mark, but you must answer all of the Assessment Criteria. The grading system for CMI qualifications is “Pass/Refer”.

If your assignment is passed, it will be uploaded to the CMI Hub, ready for verification. The verifier will sample a predetermined number of assignments from each group and ‘mark the marking’. If they agree with your tutor, your assignment will be marked as verified, and you will be notified by email.

If your assignment is ‘referred’, the issue will be identified and you will be asked to work with your tutor to agree any additional work you will need to do to achieve a verified pass. You will be asked to resubmit your revised assignment in the same way as before, but highlight any new material in your assignment in a different colour (usually red).

The assignment process is a key part of the learning to be derived from the programme. It is an output, rather than the sole objective, but it remains the best way of assessing your progress and achievement. It is often a source of anxiety for learners, for a variety of reasons. Don’t suffer in silence, ensure you engage with your tutor, other learners and the material on the VLE - they are all there to help you.



Assignment Checklist

Task/Assessment Criteria (ACs)	The task part of the question is there to give context to the learner. You must address each Assessment Criteria (AC) and include the numbers and text as headings in your assignments. This acts as a check to show that you have covered everything, and helps your tutor and the verifier identify where it has been covered.
Writing style	Use the first person ('I'), as the assignment is generally about you and what you do in the workplace. Keep it simple and concise, and avoid long passages of expansive text. Tables, charts, bullet points, etc., are all acceptable.
Word count	All CMI assignments come with a guideline word count, and there is a +/-10% leniency on this guideline. Any assignments submitted for marking that are over or under this guideline (by more or less than 10%) will be returned to the learner for editing. For example, a word count of 500-800 words will equate to 450 words as a minimum and 880 words as a maximum.
Cover page	A simple cover page to feature: your name, CMI membership number, date of submission, and word count for each task or Learning Outcome. Contents, Lists of Diagrams, Indexes and Acknowledgements are not required.
Submission	Please ensure that all documents are in a single word-processed document. If the documents are too large (5Mb and above), they will be rejected from the CMI Hub – causing a delay in the receipt and marking of your work.
Introduction and conclusion/learning log	You have up to 300 words for your introduction, and up to 500 words for your conclusion/learning log. This quota of 800 words is not included in the total word count.
Naming your assignment	Surname & Unit Number (e.g. Smith 5001)
References	Harvard style, as shown in the CMI Pathways Workbook. Remember (Author, Year) in the text, with detailed reference at the end. Example: Covey S, (1984) <i>Seven Habits of Highly Effective People</i> , Heinemann UK. You can call it References, Bibliography or Reading List – just make sure it's included, and remember that the references are not included in the total word count. Include the references you have used in the assignment, or any further reading you have completed. Don't be tempted to add pages of references that are not relevant or you have not read; you won't get any additional credit for them.
Templates	It may help you to create an assignment template – featuring a header and footer, with your name, page numbers and CMI membership number.

Command verbs	These are the directions in the Assessment Criteria, such as 'Evaluate', 'Discuss' or
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	'Identify'. Whilst the definitions might appear obvious, the CMI lists almost 70 command verbs! It is worth ensuring that you clearly understand what each command verb means during the workshop, what's required, and any other details during the discussion that relates to the assignment task.
Assignment deadlines	Your tutor/assessor may choose to set you a deadline for your assignment submission. It is important that you begin your research and preparation in good time before your assignment submission date. However, if there are extenuating circumstances that mean you are not going to be able to submit on time you should speak to your tutor/assessor as soon as possible to see if an extension is possible.
Models, tools and frameworks	The terms are used to describe a simplification of a complex idea, and are often used interchangeably. An example is the Situational Leadership Model (Hersey & Blanchard, 1968), which is used to describe adapting your management style to suit the needs of the environment or the person being managed. It's a simple four box matrix, which helps to describe a complex set of choices, responses and behaviours. The PESTLE tool (Humphrey, Brown, Porter, et. al., 1960s/1970s) is used to identify and describe internal and external factors that may affect organisational strategy, but it's usually presented as a simple acronym for Political, Environmental, Social, Technological, Legal and Economic. Models, tools and frameworks are not set in stone and should be adapted to suit the needs of the learner. For example, you can add <i>Ethical</i> to PESTLE to make the tool into STEEPLE.
'Know, Understand, Apply'	If you use a model, tool or framework to illustrate your assignment answer, then ensure you apply it effectively. Use 'Know, Understand, Apply' as a checklist. Do you <i>know</i> what the model is? Give it a name, a Harvard-style reference and a sentence to show what you are trying to achieve with the model. Can you show you <i>understand</i> how it works? Demonstrate this by <i>applying</i> it to a workplace example. Example: Unit 5009V1 AC. 2.3 Discuss the identification of and communication with all project stakeholders. "Using a Power and Interest matrix (Mendelow, 1991) I have identified four key stakeholder groups for my service development project. They include 'key players', such as my line manager; those who need to be 'kept informed' such as service users and staff (see diagram)....etc. An example of ineffective application is to copy and paste a diagram of a stakeholder matrix from the internet and claim it as your own work.
Pasting tables and text as objects and images to overcome the constraints of the word count	You should avoid creating material in other documents, taking a screenshot and inserting it into your assignment as an object. Tutors are advised to return assignments, and request additional editing. You are permitted to insert pictures from previously published sources or from flip charts created during workshop exercises, providing they are appropriately referenced.
Using 'learner-generated content' in assignments	You can photograph flip chart and whiteboard material and insert it into your assignment, providing that:

	• Your tutor approves • It is legible • It adds to your argument • It illustrates the application of a model, tool or framework • Authorship is recorded and referenced (usually your names and/or initials and date should be included on the flip chart or whiteboard material)
Appendices	Appendices are discouraged; to meet the Learning Outcomes and Assessment Criteria all work should be included within the main body of the report.

Malpractice

All instances of alleged collusion and/or plagiarism will be treated according to CMI Malpractice and Maladministration Policy. Malpractice can occur in:

- The preparation and authentication of assignments
- Conduct during an internal assessment
- Conduct during an external assessment

Examples of malpractice include:

- Plagiarism - failure to acknowledge sources properly and/or the submission of another person's work as if it were your own
- Collusion with others when an assessment must be completed by individuals
- Copying from another Learner (including using IT to do so)
- Impersonation - assuming the identity of another Learner or having someone assume your identity during an assessment
- Inclusion of inappropriate, offensive, discriminatory or obscene material in assessment evidence.

CMI may use plagiarism software to ensure that a learner's work is original, and has not been 'copied and pasted' directly from other sources. Please contact the CMI immediately should you suspect any instances of malpractice. If you are found to have committed malpractice you will be placed under investigation and potentially you will not be able to complete your qualification and your CMI membership will be revoked.